

AI for Branding

Fast first drafts of a brand identity — not the final decision

What You Will Learn

- Know the five parts of a basic brand kit.
- Use AI to generate taglines, palettes, and logo directions quickly.
- Judge AI-generated branding output against concrete criteria, not just "looks nice".
- Recognize and fix generic, cliché-prone branding prompts.

1. What Branding With AI Actually Means

AI can generate a first draft of almost anything visual or verbal that makes up a brand — logo concepts, color palettes, mood boards, taglines, even a description of "brand voice". The important word is **first draft**. AI is fast at generating options; it is not the one who should make the final branding decision for a real business — that still takes human judgment about what the brand actually stands for.

2. Building a Mini Brand Kit

A basic brand kit that AI can help draft in minutes has five parts:

- **Name** — what the business is called.
- **Tagline** — a short line capturing what it does or promises.
- **Color palette** — 3 colors, each with a reason (not just "looks nice").
- **Font pairing** — one heading font, one body font that feel consistent with the brand.
- **Brand voice** — one sentence describing how the brand "talks" (e.g. playful and casual vs precise and professional).

Example — a mini brand kit

Name: CampusBrew. Tagline: "Your study spot, minus the silence." Colors: warm brown (coffee, comfort), cream (calm, easy to read on), a bright orange accent (energy, call-to-action buttons). Fonts: a rounded, friendly heading font + a clean, simple body font. Brand voice: casual, encouraging, a little playful — talks to students like a friend, not a corporation.

3. Why Every AI Logo Looks the Same

Ask AI for "a modern logo for a tech startup" and you'll often get the same generic ingredients: a blue gradient, an abstract swirl, a geometric shape that could belong to literally any company. This happens because the prompt gave AI nothing specific to work with. The fix is the same lesson from every other chapter: vague input produces generic output. A brand-specific prompt (naming the actual personality, audience, and one thing that makes this brand different) produces a much less generic starting point.

ACTIVITY 1: Generate and Judge 5 Taglines

Step 1. Pick a real or invented business idea.

Step 2. Ask AI for 5 taglines for it.

Step 3. Pick the best one using 3 criteria: is it short, is it memorable, and is it actually honest about what the business does?

Worked example: Business: a college food delivery startup. AI taglines might include "Food, Fast, Fresh", "Your Campus, Your Cravings", "Hunger Solved". Best pick by the 3 criteria: "Your Campus, Your Cravings" — short, memorable, and specific to the actual audience (unlike the generic "Hunger Solved", which could belong to any food brand anywhere).

ACTIVITY 2: Build Two Palettes for Two Personalities

Step 1. Pick two very different brand personalities, e.g. "trustworthy and modern" (a fintech app) vs "playful and bold" (a snack brand).

Step 2. Ask AI for a 3-color palette and a one-line reason for each personality.

Step 3. Compare the two palettes — do the colors actually match the personality, or could they be swapped without anyone noticing?

Worked example: Fintech (trustworthy/modern): navy blue (stability), white (clarity), a single teal accent (modern touch). Snack brand (playful/bold): bright yellow (energy), hot pink (fun), black (bold contrast). Swapping these would immediately feel wrong — navy and white would make the snack brand feel boring, and hot pink would undercut the fintech app's trustworthiness.

ACTIVITY 3: Spot and Fix a Generic Logo Prompt

Step 1. Read this prompt: "Design a modern logo for a tech startup."

Step 2. Identify 2 cliché elements it's likely to produce (e.g. a gradient, an abstract swirl).

Step 3. Rewrite the prompt to include the brand's actual name, audience, personality, and one specific differentiator.

Worked example: Generic prompt: "Design a modern logo for a tech startup." Likely clichés: a blue-to-purple gradient, an abstract swoosh that means nothing. Rewritten: "Design a logo for 'NoteSync', a note-taking app for college students who study in groups. Personality: friendly and collaborative, not corporate. Differentiator: the logo should hint at 'sharing' or 'connection', not just a generic tech swirl."